APPENDIX 1

Common Idioms

This appendix is a mixed bag of popular Ruby idioms. They aren't really "meta," so they don't fit into the main story of this book. However, they're so common and they're the foundation of so many metaprogramming spells that you'll probably want to get familiar with them.

Mimic Methods

Much of Ruby's appeal comes from its flexible syntax. You can find an example of this flexiblity even in the most basic program:

```
puts 'Hello, world'
```

Newcomers to Ruby often mistake `puts` for a language keyword, when it's actually a method. People usually leave out the parentheses when calling `puts`, so it doesn't look like a method. Reinsert the parentheses, and the nature of `puts` becomes obvious:

```
puts('Hello, world')
```

Thanks to disguised method calls such as this one, Ruby manages to provide many useful function-like methods while keeping the core of the language relatively small and uncluttered.

This simple idea of dropping parentheses from method calls is used quite often by expert coders. Sometimes you'll want to keep the parentheses because they make a method's nature obvious—or maybe because the parser requires the parentheses to make sense of a complex line of code. Other times, you'll want to drop the parentheses to make the code cleaner or to make a method look like a keyword, as is the case with `puts`.

For another example of flexible syntax, think of object attributes, which are actually methods in disguise: